

Research Statement

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My research lies at the intersection of social policy, impact evaluation, and applied microeconomics. I study how the design, timing, and implementation of social safety nets shape the well-being of economically vulnerable populations over the life course and across generations. My work spans the mature welfare state of the United States and the evolving social protection systems of sub-Saharan Africa, with the common goal of generating evidence to inform the design of policies that expand economic opportunity.

Dissertation and Current Research Agenda

My dissertation examines how the design of cash assistance programs shapes household behavior and long-run well-being. I study this question across two distinct policy settings: U.S. welfare reform, which transformed cash assistance into a work-oriented and time-limited program, and Ghana's LEAP 1000, an unconditional cash transfer targeted to vulnerable households. These settings allow me to examine how differences in program conditions interact with household constraints to shape behavior, investments in children, and outcomes that may persist beyond benefit receipt.

My job market paper, *"Still Echoing: Welfare Reform and the Noncognitive Skill Formation of the Next Generation,"* asks whether early-life exposure to U.S. welfare reform left a lasting imprint on the human capital of the next generation. Linking the PSID core survey to the Child Development Supplement and Transition into Adulthood Supplement, I measure exposure from conception through age five and exploit variation across states, birth cohorts, and mothers' likelihood of being affected in a triple-difference design. I find that greater exposure reduced noncognitive skills (NCS) in young adulthood among children born to likely affected mothers, with declines concentrated in agreeableness and openness and largest among those exposed earliest in life. Mechanism evidence is suggestive of changes in early caregiving conditions rather than household income or maternal employment. Yet I find no corresponding decline in adult earnings or employment, indicating that the developmental consequences of welfare reform extend beyond outcomes conventionally captured by the labor market. The paper highlights the importance of both developmental timing and outcomes beyond intended beneficiaries when evaluating safety-net reforms.

A second dissertation paper, *"From Cradle to Courtroom? Early-Life Exposure to Welfare Reform and Long-Run Criminal Justice Contact,"* follows the same exposed cohorts into adulthood to examine effects on arrest, incarceration, and probation. This project extends my analysis beyond NCS to ask whether early exposure to changes in the safety net manifests in consequential interactions with the criminal justice system years later.

My final dissertation essay shifts to Ghana while retaining my focus on how program design interacts with household circumstances. In joint work, *"Cash Transfers and the Labor Supply of Vulnerable Households and Individuals: Does Household Indebtedness Matter?,"* we examine how pre-existing financial obligations condition labor-supply responses to Ghana's LEAP 1000. While the transfer reduces wage and total work hours on average, indebted beneficiaries increase wage work, nonfarm enterprise activity, and total hours, with responses varying by the nature of the debt. The findings show that identical transfers can generate markedly different responses depending on the constraints households bring into a program. This heterogeneity complements my U.S. work by showing that understanding the effects of social protection requires attention both to when policies reach households and the conditions under which households receive them.

Research Foundations and Ongoing Research

Before my dissertation, I built a research program on social protection, household welfare, and institutional engagement in sub-Saharan Africa that continues to anchor my international development agenda. In joint

work, I find that broader social-protection coverage is associated with more inclusive growth across the region, that international remittances strengthen multiple dimensions of women's empowerment, and that agricultural extension services improve household assets, food consumption, and dietary diversity in Ghana. A consistent theme is that resources delivered through public programs and private transfers translate into household wellbeing unevenly, in ways that depend on economic and social context, the same heterogeneity that motivates my current work.

A second line examines how citizens understand and engage with policy. In my sole-authored "*Universal Access, Divided Opinions*," published in *Social Policy and Society*, I use latent class analysis to show that Ghana's universal Free Senior High School policy produced distinct configurations of public opinion rather than uniform support. Joint work on corruption reporting examines how education, economic security, civic engagement, and trust shape citizens' willingness to use formal accountability institutions. This work established a conviction that runs through my agenda: policy effectiveness depends not only on benefits and formal rules, but on how citizens interpret those rules, judge their legitimacy, and respond to public institutions.

Building on my work on the long-run legacy of welfare reform, another set of projects in my pipeline examines whether early-life exposure shapes health mobility and wealth accumulation across adulthood. These projects extend my interest in how safety-net policies alter trajectories of well-being and economic security long after initial exposure. I also extend my focus on policy spillovers beyond intended beneficiaries by examining whether Ghana's Free Senior High School reform affected the educational outcomes of younger siblings within households. Another project studies how administrative burden and political ideology shape public support for SNAP work requirements among college students.

Future Directions

My future agenda broadens from evaluating individual cash assistance programs to understanding the wider architecture of social protection. In the U.S., I will move beyond cash assistance to study other components of the safety net, particularly SNAP, WIC, the Earned Income Tax Credit, and the Child Tax Credit. I will examine how differences in program design, work incentives, and administrative requirements shape household decision-making, financial resilience, wealth accumulation, health, labor-market attachment, and children's developmental trajectories. Beyond individual programs, I will examine how different combinations of public safety-net programs and private support shape household economic security and longer-run mobility.

In sub-Saharan Africa, I will extend this framework to study the long-run consequences of social protection beyond the short-run outcomes that dominate the existing evidence, with particular attention to human capital, health, wealth accumulation, labor-market trajectories, and intergenerational mobility. I will also study the broader mix of resources households use to manage vulnerability, including multiple public programs and private safety nets such as international remittances. This work will examine how the composition and combination of these resources shape household investment, resilience, and longer-run mobility across different institutional settings.

I also plan to incorporate microsimulation to assess the distributional and long-run implications of proposed reforms before their full effects become observable. This will allow my research to move from evaluating individual programs toward studying how alternative safety-net configurations might reshape resources and opportunity across households and generations. Overall, these directions provide natural opportunities for externally funded research through the Russell Sage Foundation, Robert Wood Johnson Foundation, NIH, USDA, and NSF, as well as funders supporting social protection and poverty reduction in sub-Saharan Africa.